
The 2025
Autonomous IT Report
**Agentic AI and the
Future of Enterprise IT**

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Executive Summary

Enterprise AI has reached a pivotal moment. After several years of accelerating investment in automation and generative AI, organizations are now moving decisively toward **Agentic AI**: systems designed not just to process information, but to reason, adapt, and collaborate as part of operational workflows.

This evolution signals a strategic shift in how enterprises create value. No longer confined to efficiency gains or cost reduction, AI is beginning to reshape the role of IT itself – from a necessary operational function to a **profit-driving, strategic capability**.

This report draws on responses from 600 IT decision-makers across large North American organizations that have implemented AI within the last two years. Nearly every respondent reports meaningful progress on AI adoption. Trust in AI is high, confidence in its potential is widespread, and many organizations already see tangible financial return.

Yet, the research also reveals complex dynamics beneath the surface: the growing cost of AI, the continued reliance on human expertise, and the organizational challenge of scaling systems that are both intelligent and adaptive.

The shift to Agentic AI is not about replacing human contribution. Instead, it reflects the growing recognition that AI and human capability are most powerful when combined. Agentic AI systems are emerging as collaborative partners, enabling IT and operations teams to focus on higher-order work, accelerate issue resolution, strengthen decision-making, and drive measurable business impact.

The enterprise is moving beyond automation. It is entering the era of the autonomous enterprise.



Across three consecutive studies, Digitate's global research has tracked the shift of enterprise IT from early automation to intelligent systems. What began as a cost-saving exercise is maturing into a profit-driving strategy. Indeed, in just three years, enterprise AI has matured from an operational utility to a strategic capability – one trusted, governed, and delivering measurable ROI. "

– Avi Bhagtani, CMO, Digitate

Introduction:

From Automation to Autonomous



The enterprise AI journey has evolved quickly over the past three years. In 2023, many organizations focused on automating routine tasks and reducing operational complexity. By 2024, the focus had broadened to the integration of AI into business and IT workflows, though maturity and governance varied significantly.

By 2025, in North America, adoption has accelerated and expectations have shifted. Organizations are not only implementing AI; they are working to scale it, standardize it, and extract greater strategic value from it. This evolution reflects a broader shift from automation, where tasks are streamlined or accelerated, to autonomous IT, where systems collaborate with human teams to anticipate needs, propose actions, and support or execute decision pathways.

Purpose of this Report

Digitate's current research provides an in-depth view of how Agentic AI is influencing enterprise maturity and operational performance. It draws on our previous research in [2023 \(North America\)](#) and [2024 \(Europe\)](#) to understand how enterprise priorities, outcomes, and challenges have evolved over time. The findings presented here are intended to support IT leadership teams as they plan, scale, and govern the next phase of AI-enabled transformation.

The survey investigates:

- Adoption and utilization of AI and Agentic AI.
- Current and future levels of AI maturity and trust.
- Obstacles to implementation and value realization.
- How enterprises plan to measure and scale the impact of AI initiatives.

Definitions

- AI tools: Systems that execute defined, often generative, functions within set parameters.
- Agentic AI: Broader intelligent systems that reason, adapt, and act autonomously toward defined goals.
- AI agents: Specific task-oriented implementations of agentic capabilities within IT or business processes.

Methodology

600 IT decision-makers in the United States and Canada from organizations with 1,000+ employees that have implemented AI within the past 24 months, were surveyed online by Sapio Research (Sept–Oct 2025).

Results are accurate to $\pm 4\%$ at the 95% confidence level.

Key Findings

- **High trust and confidence:** **94%** of respondents consider AI **trustworthy**.
- **Rapid progression toward autonomous:** **45%** of organizations currently operate as semi to fully autonomous enterprises, rising to a projected **74%** within five years.
- **Proven financial return and increased productivity/efficiency:** KPIs used to evaluate AI implementation success focus on productivity, efficiency and ROI, with a median return of **\$175** million from AI implementations.
- **Agentic AI in the ascendant:** **61%** of IT leaders see agentic systems not merely as automation tools but as intelligent collaborators augmenting human capability.
- **The human involvement conundrum:** The need for human intervention is the main drawback of AI implementation **(47%)** to date, and lack of technical skills **(33%)** the primary inhibitor to further AI adoption.

Section 1

The Current State of Enterprise AI

1.1 Adoption and Maturity

Adoption of AI is now universal, but the story of maturity is one of evolution and differentiation.

Every organization surveyed has implemented AI in the last two years, using an average of five AI tools across multiple functions. Generative AI remains the most widely deployed (74%), while over two in five have already introduced agentic (44%) or agent-based AI (43%).

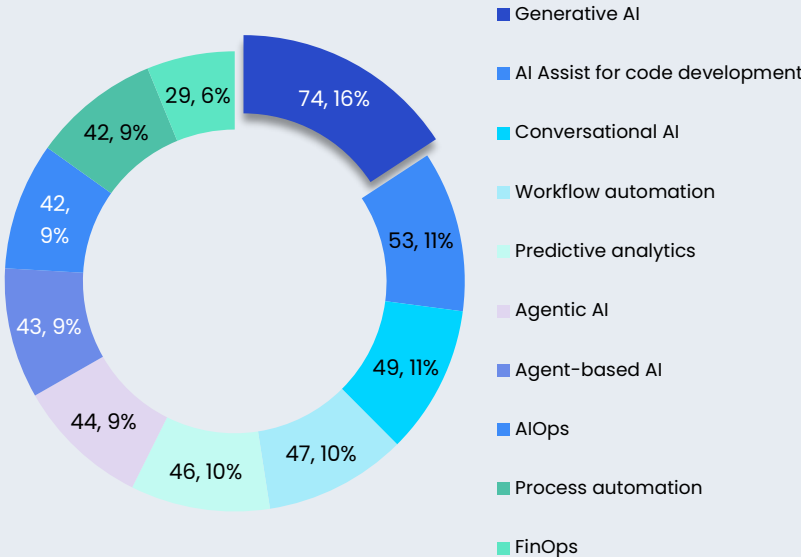
The current data highlights a three-year progression that began with automation in 2023 and evolved through integrated AI and automation in 2024, reflecting a steady climb from automation as an operational necessity to AI as a strategic enabler. Indeed, nearly three-quarters expect to operate at least semi-autonomously by 2030.

In 2023, enterprises were primarily focused on streamlining processes and reducing manual overhead. By 2024, European organizations were experimenting with generative and predictive models while prioritizing data governance. By 2025, North American enterprises have entered the Agentic AI stage, characterized by value realization and growing autonomy. ROI has been consistent across regions, and adoption has become embedded in core IT and business operations.

This cross-year evolution underscores a broader pattern: as automation matures, organizations transition from reactive, tactical adoption, to proactive, strategic operations, laying the groundwork for the fully autonomous enterprise.

AI tools leveraged to date

On average, organizations have leveraged
5 AI tools



The Evolution of Enterprise AI

2023	Automation	Median ROI
	Efficiency, productivity, complexity reduction	(qualitative only)
2024	AI + Automation	
	Rapid adoption, fragmented strategy	€155M (~\$170 M)
2025	Agentic AI	
	Value realization and autonomy	\$175 M

1.2 The Trust Paradox

Confidence in AI remains strong across all segments, with nine in ten of respondents expressing trust in AI systems. However, this trust is not reflected equally across roles. Our 2025 data shows important contrasts:

- C-suite leaders express higher trust, with 61% saying AI is very trustworthy, and greater optimism about AI's potential to drive productivity and autonomy. They frame AI as a financial and strategic lever.
- Only 46% of practitioners and non-C-suite roles report high trust levels, tempered by day-to-day exposure to technical considerations. Their perspective emphasizes reliability, transparency, and the need for continued human oversight.

This divergence reflects a “strategy–execution gap”: Leadership sees AI as a path to long-term transformation, while practitioners focus on pragmatic delivery and governance. Both perspectives are essential. The trust dynamic within organizations highlights the importance of collaboration between those setting AI strategy and those implementing it.

C-Suite vs Non-C-Suite

Theme	C-Suite	Non-C-Suite	Interpretation
Autonomous Future (5 yrs)	≈ 90% expect semi/full autonomy	≈ 71%	Leaders foresee faster transformation.
Primary Value Metric	ROI & profitability	Efficiency & accuracy	Top-down financial framing vs. operational KPIs.
Top Barriers	Governance, cost control	Technical skills, integration	Strategic vs. tactical obstacles.

AI-Specific Roles vs Non-AI Roles

Theme	AI-Specific Functions	General IT / Ops Roles	Interpretation
Trust Level	Slightly lower	Slightly higher	Hands-on experts are more aware of model limits and data risks.
Perceived Benefits	Data quality & predictive insight	Efficiency & time savings	Technical vs. business lenses on value.
Top Barriers	Integration complexity, model transparency	Skills gap, maintenance cost	‘Technical vs talent’ divide.
View of Agentic AI	Cautiously adaptive	Augmentation-first	Practitioners foresee stepwise adaptation rather than full autonomy.

1.3 Investments and Returns

AI investment is both significant and accelerating.
Across respondents:

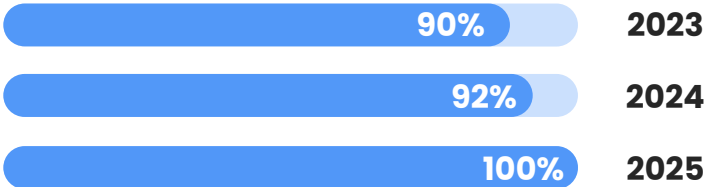
- Average implementation spend: **\$187M**
- Average realized return: **\$221M**

The magnitude of these figures reinforces that AI is now a board-level priority, no longer confined to experimentation or pilot initiatives. Compared to our previous studies, ROI has increased roughly 30% year over year. In 2023, automation delivered measurable efficiencies; in 2024, European enterprises reported average ROI of roughly \$170M; by 2025, North American organizations are consistently reporting returns above \$175M.

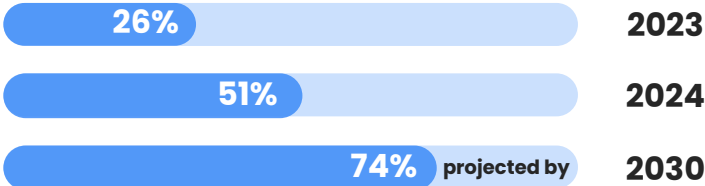
North America's leadership in ROI reflects faster operational scaling and greater risk tolerance, while Europe's measured pace continues to set benchmarks for governance and compliance. Together, these trends illustrate a global convergence on value: AI is now delivering both financial and strategic returns across markets.

Maturity milestones

Adoption



Semi-autonomous enterprise



Average implementation spend



Section 2

IT as the Proving Ground for AI

2.1 Where AI Delivers the Most Value

Across three years of Digitate's research, one constant is clear: IT is both the testing ground and the proving ground for enterprise AI.

In 2025, that position has only strengthened. AI deployments are most mature within IT operations, where complexity, data richness, and the demand for precision create ideal conditions for autonomous intelligence.

More than three-quarters (78%) of respondents have deployed AI in IT operations —the highest rate of any business function. Planned deployments (70%) remain equally strong, while 65% of organizations cite ITOps as the function deriving the most benefit from AI —indicating that IT continues to be the foundation upon which AI capabilities are scaled across the enterprise.

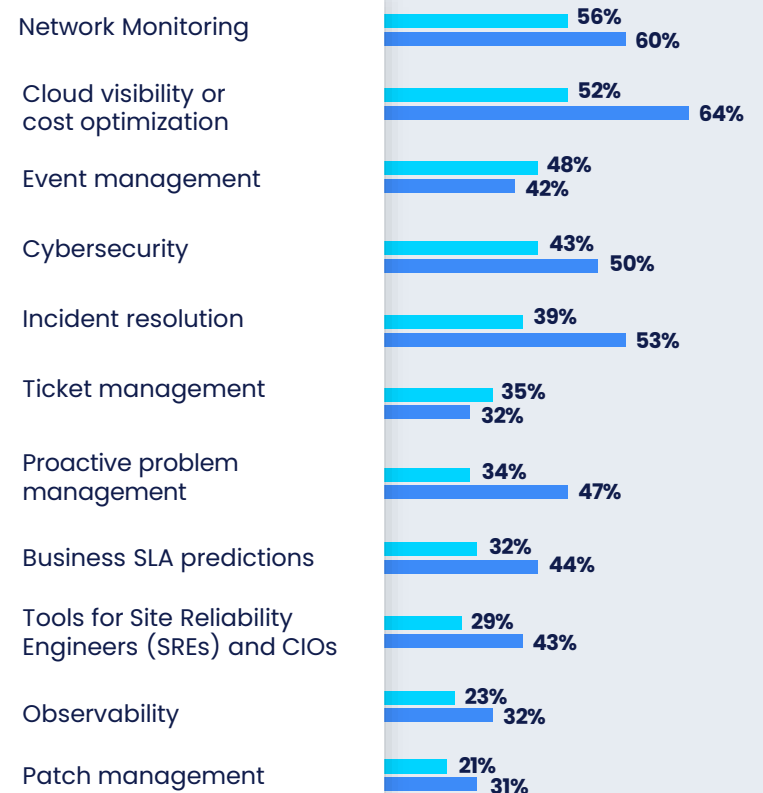
The top areas of implementation include:

- **Cloud visibility and cost optimization (52%)** – using AI to interpret vast telemetry data and anomaly detection in real-time, as well as providing a single, unified view of spending data across multi-cloud and hybrid environments.
- **IT event management (48%)** – where AI-powered tools provide efficiency, automation, and data-driven decision-making..

What makes IT a particularly attractive domain for AI is its dual nature: it sits at the intersection of process and intelligence. IT environments are data-intensive and structured for AI models to learn from; at the same time, they are dynamic enough to require human judgment and adaptive reasoning.

AI thrives in that balance: complementing human expertise rather than displacing it.

AI in IT today vs in the next 12 months



2.2 Business Value: Accuracy, Efficiency, and Intelligence

IT's embrace of AI has measurable impact. Enterprises that have scaled AI within IT operations report not only improvements in decision accuracy and quality (44%), improved efficiency (43%), but also stronger data management (42%).

- **Improved accuracy:** AI reduces manual errors and accelerates diagnosis.
- **Increased efficiency:** Teams can handle higher workloads with fewer escalations.
- **Enhanced data management:** AI agents organize and contextualize system data for cross-functional use.

Organizations that invest more heavily in AI (typically those with implementation budgets above \$500 million) see the strongest correlation between AI maturity and ROI. These enterprises are effectively transforming IT from an operational enabler into a strategic intelligence function; one that contributes directly to business performance metrics such as revenue enablement, cost avoidance, and customer experience.

2.3 Persistent Challenges

However, this evolution also exposes new dependencies. The very success of AI in IT brings growing operational demands: maintaining model accuracy, integrating diverse systems, and ensuring governance over data and decision logic. Nearly all organizations (**94%**) report at least one drawback in their AI implementation, with **human oversight (47%)**, **cost (42%)** and **maintenance (41%)** among the top concerns.

This reinforces IT's unique position: it is both the innovation engine for enterprise AI and the governance anchor, reinforcing its role as a complementary tool to human capabilities and ensuring that innovation remains controlled, compliant, and sustainable.

Section 3

The Rise of Agentic AI

3.1 From Automation to Collaboration

If the first two waves of enterprise automation and AI adoption centered on accuracy, efficiency and cost reduction, the next phase of Agentic AI is changing this paradigm from automation to collaboration.

Agentic systems can interpret dynamic conditions, reason through ambiguity, and engage in goal-oriented workflows. Instead of executing predefined tasks, they are able to collaborate, both with systems and with people, to deliver outcomes.

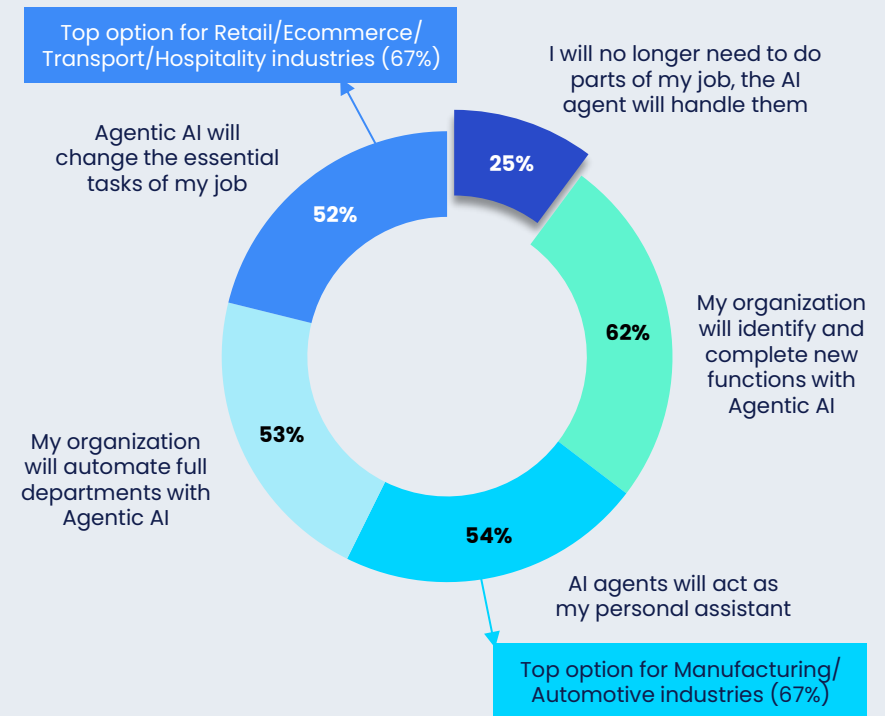
In this model, the role of humans also evolves. IT and business leaders are shifting from managing systems to orchestrating collaboration between humans and AI agents, where agents act as digital teammates: proactive, context-aware, and continuously learning from feedback loops.

3.2 Expectations and Early Adoption

The data shows that enterprises are at an inflection point in their AI evolution:

- 62% expect Agentic AI to assist in new or previously unsupported functions.
- 54% expect AI agents to act as workflow or personal assistants, working alongside humans and helping to automate contextual, day-to-day activities.
- 53% envisage Agentic AI as enabling full departmental automation.
- 52% believe Agentic AI will reshape essential tasks within their roles.

Agentic AI functions



Adoption is strongest within **IT operations (67%)**, **customer-support (46%)** and **automated reporting (44%)**/software development (44%) **functions** – environments where complexity and data intensity demand adaptive, decision-oriented systems. Across these domains, Agentic AI is already driving measurable impact by improving service quality, responsiveness, and predictive accuracy.

AI agent use cases today have proven most successful in enabling customer self-service (**49%**) and reporting & analytics (**48%**) – the only two functions where AI agents are currently considered more useful than traditional AI tools. However, notably, among the high adopters of AI, **67%** deem AI agents most successful in reporting & analytics – reinforcing the technology's potential to unlock human skills.

3.3 Deployment Plans and Strategic Impact

The emergence of Agentic AI signifies more than technological evolution; it marks the beginning of a new operational model.

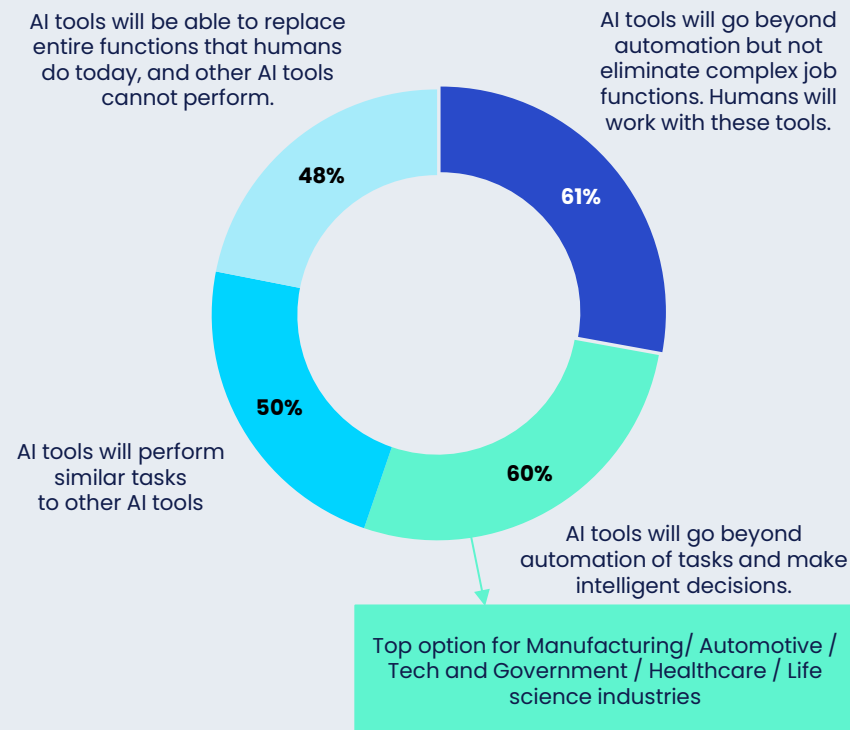
Deployment plans for 2026 show continued expansion across nearly all IT domains, with particularly strong momentum in cost optimization (65%), proactive problem management (55%) and cybersecurity (53%).

Meanwhile:

- **60%** of enterprises believe Agentic AI enables **intelligent decision-making**, providing insight and foresight beyond what static systems can deliver.
- **61%** believe it will **extend human capacity for complex job functions**, particularly in IT and operations.

This represents the early convergence of automation, analytics, and autonomy; where technology amplifies human expertise, improves decision velocity, and unlocks measurable business value.

Impact and value of Agentic AI



Agentic AI is not replacing the human enterprise; it is augmenting it – creating intelligent systems that think alongside people, accelerating both innovation and impact.

Section 4

Obstacles, Risks, and Readiness: Navigating the Cost–Human Conundrum

As AI becomes embedded across enterprise operations, organizations face an increasingly complex equation: how to scale AI affordably while maintaining the human capability needed to sustain it.

Digitate's latest findings expose a persistent dilemma: AI is deployed to reduce human workload and operational cost, yet those very same forces remain the primary barriers to its growth.

This “cost–human conundrum” defines the next challenge for AI maturity – balancing automation's promise with the realities of economics, skills, and oversight.

4.1 External and Internal Risk Landscape

Organizations identify a mix of external pressures and internal structural risks shaping their AI strategy.

External Risks

External threats are dominated by financial and security pressures:

- **Cybersecurity** is cited by **49%** of respondents as the most significant external risk.
- The **rising cost of technology** ranks second (**42%**), reflecting inflationary pressures on infrastructure, cloud compute, and AI model training.
- **Macroeconomic concerns** come third (**36%**), as organizations prepare to manage risks like recession or inflation.

Crucially, AI is also seen as a means to mitigate several of these risks.

39%
Mitigate
security risk

28%
Control
technology costs

22%
Offset
workforce costs

While 22% are turning to AI to offset workforce cost pressures – **32%** of organizations noted the **rising labour cost** as a key risk – by automating manual processes and scaling productivity.

However, few are using AI to directly address **employee retention** or **engagement** – a notable blind spot given that talent scarcity remains one of the top obstacles to success.

Internal Risks

Internally, the risks shift from economics to complexity.

- **IT complexity** tops the list, cited by **37%** of respondents.
- **Profitability and cost efficiency** rank joint second (**31%**), followed by change resistance and distrust concerns.

In both areas, organizations are already applying AI: nearly half have deployed AI solutions to **simplify IT environments (28%)** or **improve financial performance (22%)**. This reflects a clear pattern: enterprises increasingly view AI as a structural remedy for operational risk.

AI has become both the source of and the solution to enterprise complexity, mitigating the very challenges it sometimes amplifies.

4.2 Drawbacks and Obstacles

While AI's potential is broadly acknowledged, implementation realities continue to test organizations.

When asked about AI and automation drawbacks , two themes dominate:

- **Human intervention remains necessary (47%)**, as AI systems still need oversight, tuning, and exception management.
- **Cost of AI implementation and maintenance** ranks closely behind **(42%)**, driven by model retraining, integration, and cloud infrastructure.

At the same time, the top three obstacles to further adoption include:

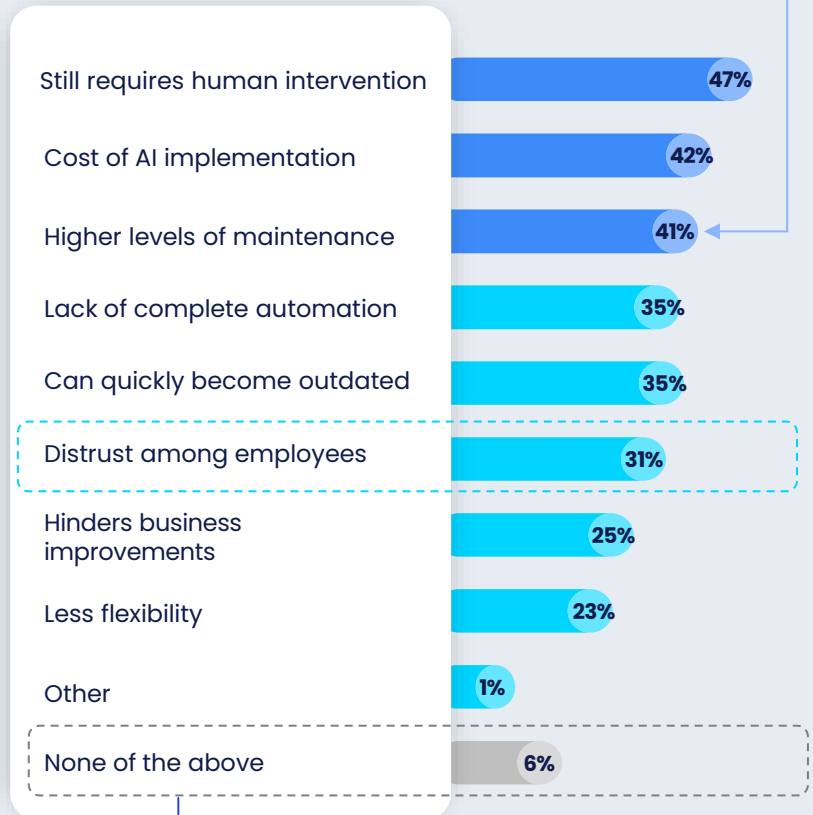
- **Lack of technical skills** or need to upskill **(33%)**,
- **Lack of Data collection and management to make AI most valuable (32%), and**
- **Lack of budget** to implement AI **(31%)**.



Distrust among employees plays a major role in why **45%** believe AI isn't fully trustworthy

Drawbacks of AI tools implemented in last two years

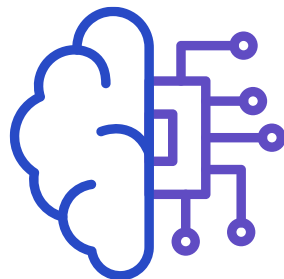
Although AI and automation are designed to improve efficiency and time spent on tasks, there are still concerns from half around **human intervention, costs and high levels of maintenance**



94%

Highlight that they have experienced drawback with implemented AI tools

Taken together, these factors reinforce the paradox at the heart of AI adoption: **AI is intended to reduce cost and dependence on human labor, yet achieving that outcome demands both skilled people and sustained funding.**

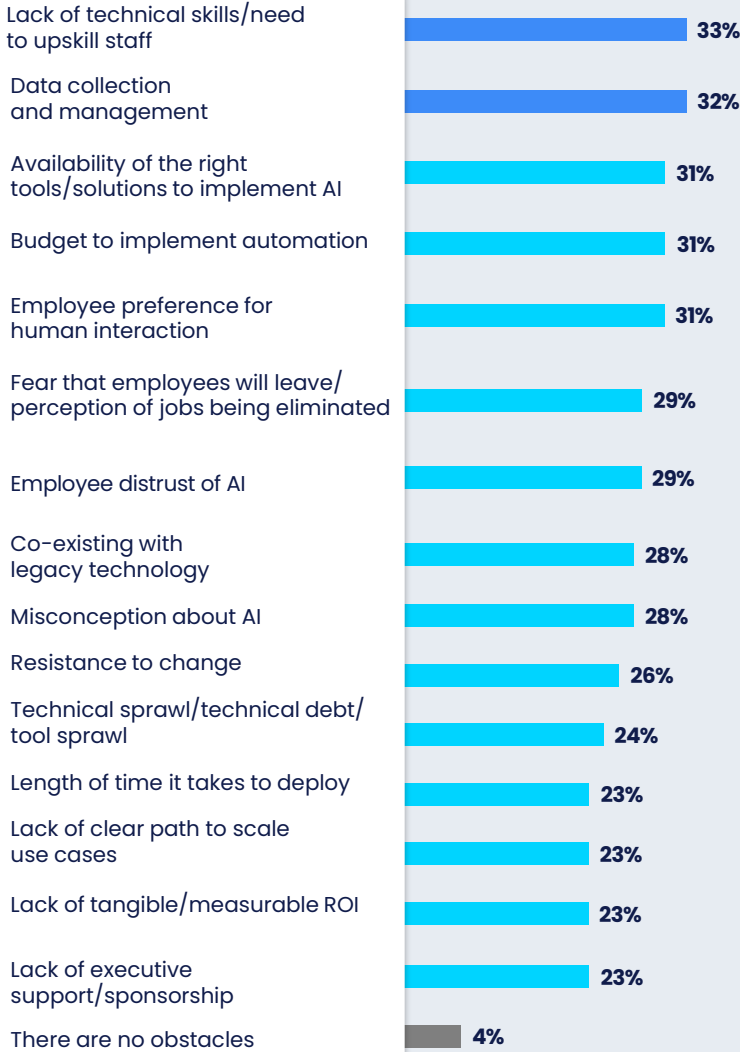


96%
are currently facing obstacles to
adopting AI or automation



With 96% of organization facing barriers to AI implementation, it is evident that accessibility and usability of AI is currently acting as a blocker from fully adopting AI.

Obstacles to adopting AI in next 12 months



4.3 The Cost–Human Conundrum Explained

Enterprises are simultaneously navigating three intersecting pressures:

Enterprises are simultaneously navigating three intersecting pressures:



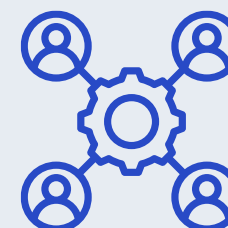
The human factor: Skilled professionals are indispensable for developing, monitoring, and governing AI. Demand for this talent exceeds supply.



The financial factor: As AI sophistication grows, so too do its cost. Computing power, data management, and compliance investments all rise in tandem.



The strategic factor: Leadership expects AI to deliver measurable ROI and cost efficiency, creating near-term pressure for rapid payback.



The result is a self-reinforcing loop:

AI investment increases operational capacity but also raises human and financial dependencies.

Organizations must therefore approach AI not as a static tool but as an evolving ecosystem requiring governance, workforce strategy, and financial foresight.

This tension underscores the maturity challenge of 2025 and beyond: enterprises are not questioning if AI delivers value, but rather how to sustain that value amid escalating costs and limited human capacity. The winners will be those that manage to balance automation with augmentation – optimizing cost without eroding the human expertise that powers AI's success.

Section 5

The Autonomous Horizon: From Trust to Transformation

5.1 From Maturity to Momentum

Enterprises have spent the last three years learning how to embed AI responsibly. Now they are preparing to scale it strategically.

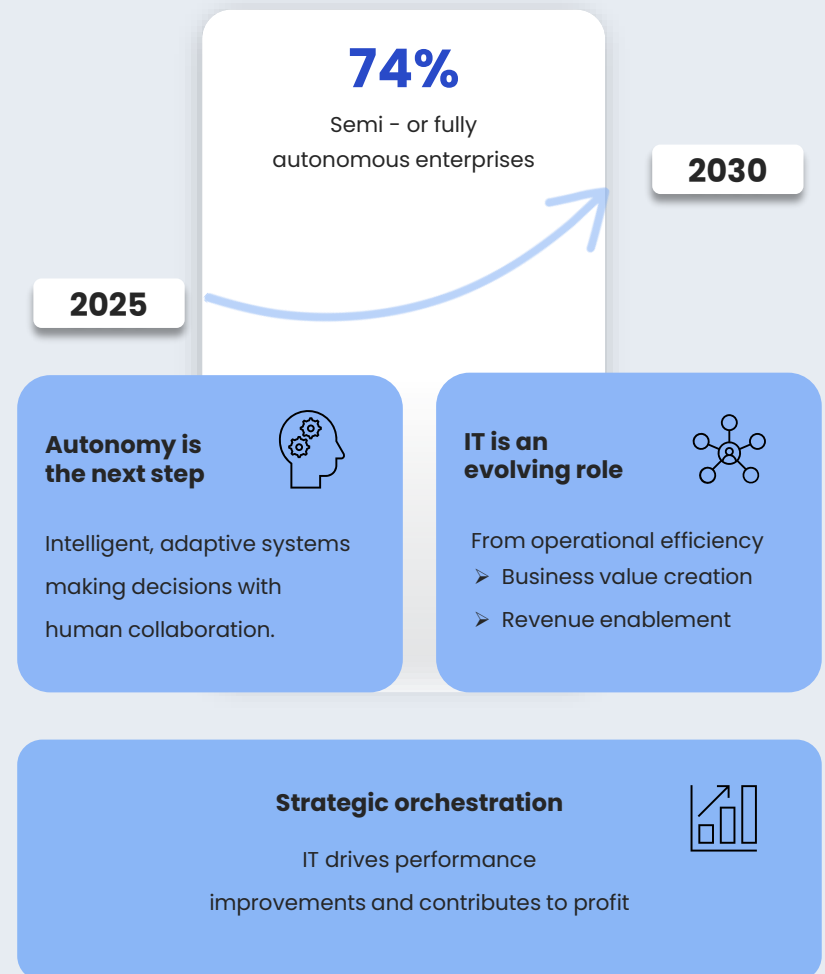
Our latest data reveals strong confidence in the road ahead: nearly three-quarters (**74%**) of organizations expect to operate as **semi- or fully autonomous enterprises** within the next five years. This marks a major leap from 2023, when only a quarter envisioned such autonomy.

The autonomous enterprise is no longer a distant aspiration: it is the logical next step in enterprise evolution. The foundations built through automation and AI adoption are giving rise to intelligent, adaptive systems that can make decisions, coordinate resources, and optimize performance with collaborative human intervention.

Meanwhile, IT's role – as the primary proving ground for Agentic AI – will continue shifting from operational efficiency to business value creation and revenue enablement.

As AI capabilities mature, IT will increasingly act as a strategic orchestrator, driving performance improvements across functions and directly contributing to profit and growth.

Scaling AI Strategically in 2025 and Beyond



5.2 Readiness for What Comes Next

While enthusiasm for autonomous operations is high, readiness is uneven. The survey highlights both progress and persistent gaps across four critical dimensions of maturity:

- **Governance and Accountability**

Most organizations have established AI governance frameworks, but many remain policy-heavy and operationally light. True readiness will mean embedding governance directly into system design; ensuring transparency, traceability, and ethical oversight in every decision loop.

- **Data and Infrastructure**

Reliable autonomous operations depend on consistent, high-quality data. The most progressive enterprises are investing heavily in data integration and observability platforms to give AI agents the context they need to act accurately and independently.

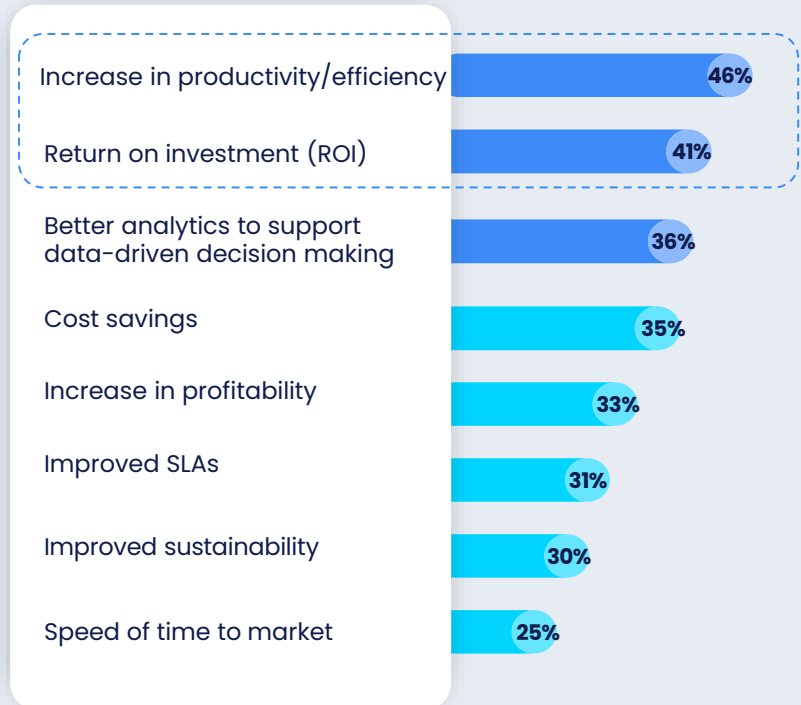
- **Human Capability and Skills**

Workforce readiness is emerging as the defining factor of success. The next generation of IT professionals will combine technical depth with governance literacy and business fluency. Organizations that invest early in hybrid skillsets – e.g. operations plus data science, compliance plus automation – will scale autonomy faster and more safely.

- **Performance and ROI Orientation**

The measure of success is shifting from efficiency to sustainability and business resilience. Autonomy will create value not only by lowering cost, but by enabling predictive action, faster recovery, and continuous learning across the enterprise.

KPIs/measure prioritized to evaluate success of AI initiatives



With productivity and efficiency topping the prioritized KPIs, this underscores how organizations are already recognizing AI's capabilities as reflected in the benefits realized and the strong ROI that is being delivered.

5.3 Strategic Implications

As organizations advance toward the autonomous enterprise, several implications become clear:



IT becomes the orchestration layer: the system of systems, through which all intelligent agents interact.



Data governance becomes strategy, not compliance: AI's credibility will rest on transparency and explainability.



Human roles will evolve, focusing on oversight, creativity, and interpretation rather than execution.



Value creation metrics will change, measuring contribution to innovation, resilience, and profitability rather than simple cost avoidance.



Autonomous operations, therefore, is not about replacing the human enterprise; it is about expanding it.

The organizations that will lead in the next decade are those that treat Agentic AI not merely as technology, but as an organizational philosophy, where humans and AI collaborate to pursue shared business outcomes.

Enterprise autonomy is not the end of human work. It's the amplification of human judgment at machine scale.

Conclusion

Over three years of research, Digitate has tracked a clear progression: from **automation for efficiency** to **AI for intelligence**, and now to **Agentic AI for enterprise value creation**.

What began as a cost-saving measure has evolved into a strategic driver of business growth, resilience, and innovation.

By now, enterprise AI is no longer an experimental technology: it is a trusted operational capability delivering measurable financial impact. Organizations report both higher ROI and greater confidence in AI's ability to support decision-making, governance, and performance. Yet, as this report shows, the enterprise challenge has shifted. Success is no longer defined by adoption alone, but by the ability to **scale AI sustainably**, balancing automation with human judgment and cost with capability.

Agentic AI represents the next inflection point.

These intelligent, goal-oriented systems are enabling enterprises to move from reactive operations to proactive, autonomous ecosystems, where IT acts as a strategic orchestrator and ROI enabler. The rise of Agentic AI and AI agents, working in tandem with human teams, signals a future in which organizations can anticipate change, adapt dynamically, and unlock new dimensions of business value.

The road to the autonomous enterprise will require continued investment in **trust, transparency, and talent**. Governance frameworks must evolve from policy to practice, ensuring that every AI-driven decision is explainable and aligned to enterprise ethics. Workforce strategies must focus on upskilling and hybrid expertise, preparing humans and machines to collaborate seamlessly.

Enterprises that succeed will be those that view AI not as a technology initiative, but as an organizational philosophy: a new way of operating where intelligence, adaptability, and accountability coexist.

In this new era of Agentic AI, IT is no longer a cost of doing business—it is the engine that drives it.

About

About Digitate

Digitate is a leading software provider bringing agility, assurance, and resiliency to IT and business operations. Digitate's flagship product, ignio™, is an award-winning AIOps solution that reimagines the enterprise business landscape with its distinctive closed-loop approach. It combines context, insights, and intelligent automation to resolve, prevent, and predict issues autonomously. Our customers span multiple industries and include global enterprises that are leaders and innovators.

To stay up to date on ignio™ news and learn how our clients across the globe have benefited from our innovative solutions, visit us at digitate.com and follow Digitate on [X](#) and [LinkedIn](#).

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Our purpose-driven team of expert market researchers is passionate about providing data confidence for all and performing research that makes a difference. We're here to support our clients every step of the way in all areas of quantitative and qualitative research, so they can save time and thinking space, deliver with confidence, and unlock more value with their research. sapioresearch.com



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